Fiction Without Hidden Facts

2026-10-23

Abstract Does a story that never says how a tossed coin landed nonetheless make one answer true? Blumberg and Holguín argue that it does, in two stages. Our attitudes toward what a fiction leaves open, and the logic of our talk about it, are said to require a single world that settles every question; and counterfactuals locate it, since what is true in a fiction is what would be true if its settled claims were true, on Stalnaker's semantics. I reject both stages. A semantics on which fictional claims are evaluated against the information a story provides, weighted by a Reality Principle for credence, predicts the attitudes and the logic with no single world, and, given two bridge principles their view needs, agrees with theirs on every attitude toward a single fiction. And fiction and counterfactuals come apart: a detail that bears on a chancy outcome can change the outcome when added to a counterfactual's antecedent, but not when added to a story that leaves the outcome open. The facts Blumberg and Holguín posit are located by nothing our judgements track, and Lewis's verdict, that the worlds of a fiction are plural, is the better-supported view.

1 Lewis's question

When Holmes first meets Watson, does he have an odd or an even number of hairs on his head? Lewis thought it "absurd to suppose that these questions about the world of Sherlock Holmes have answers", and drew the moral that "the worlds of Sherlock Holmes are plural" (Lewis 1978, 42). Blumberg and Holguín (2025) argue that he was wrong: "for any given work of fiction, there is a single world that determines what's true in it, and that world is as rich in detail as reality itself" (176). The parity of Holmes's hairs is "as factual as the question of whether he is a detective" (151). We just cannot know it.

Their case (hereafter B&H's) has two stages. The first argues *that* there is a single world. Our attitudes toward what a fiction leaves open have a distinctive profile: we can wonder whether a coin tossed at the end of a television series landed heads, think a biased coin more likely than not to have done so, and hope it did, but we cannot know or be sure how it landed. The standard view of truth in fiction cannot explain this profile. B&H argue that the way fictional claims embed, under attitude verbs and under negation and quantifiers, requires fictional excluded middle, and with it a single world. Judgements about embedding patterns, they say, are what "primarily" drive their case (183 n. 53). The second stage says *where* the world is. By their PRINCIPAL REALITY

PRINCIPLE (PRP), what is true in a fiction is what would be true if its settled claims were true, on Stalnaker's semantics for counterfactuals. Fictional truth is counterfactual truth, and that is why the facts are unknowable.

I argue that both stages fail. Against the first, I give a semantics on which bare fictional claims, and attitudes toward them, are evaluated against the information a work provides, weighted by a Reality Principle for credence (Section 3). It validates the inference and the equivalences B&H's embedding argument rests on, and it predicts their attitude profile, all with no single world. And given two bridge principles their view needs, it agrees with theirs on every attitude toward a single fiction. B&H consider this option, that there being "no fact of the matter" about whether p "is perfectly compatible with one's rationally having opinions about p, wondering whether p, and so on" (167), and set it aside because of the embedding arguments, crediting Khoo (2022) with a related line about counterfactuals (167 n. 33). The semantics answers those arguments. Against the second stage, I give a test that separates fiction from counterfactuals, which attitudes toward a single fiction cannot do (Section 4). Strengthen the antecedent of a counterfactual with a detail that bears on a chancy outcome, and the outcome can change. Add the same detail to a story without settling the outcome, and it does not. The PRP treats these as one operation, so it fails the test, and every way of saving it adds a rule for fiction that counterfactuals reject. What remains is a single world that nothing locates and no judgement tracks (Section 5).

The alternative is not new in spirit. Lewis held the worlds of a fiction to be plural. Williams and Woodward argued that our attitude to what a fiction leaves open is an imaginative credence that "should match the conditional probability of p given the fictive evidence", because "there are, so to speak, no fictional facts of the matter" (Williams and Woodward 2021, 424, 423). Woodward completed fictionalists' stories with a counterfactual that obeys conditional excluded middle, but made it indeterminate which completion is the story's (Woodward 2012, 787), unless the indeterminacy is epistemic, an option he leaves open (2012, 789) that is in effect B&H's view; B&H note the affinity (183 n. 53). Badura and Berto (2019) model truth in fiction as belief revision, Oppy and Raivars (2026) contest B&H's data, and Khoo (2026, 1191, §4) reports contrasting judgements for explicit "in the fiction of" reports, which B&H set aside (153), and treats them by supervaluating over selections.

The closest relative of my view is Khoo's case against "middle facts" about what would have happened under unrealised chancy antecedents, together with his account of how we can still "leave open the possibility" of such counterfactuals (Khoo 2022, 1000, 1014). A belief state is lifted to pairs of a world and a selection function, the latter "encoding a maximally specific set of inferential dispositions" rather than fixing facts, and a claim is factually true when it holds on every selection function (Khoo 2022, 1013–14). The story-state view does for fiction what Khoo does for counterfactuals, with two differences. On Khoo's model, as on any supervaluation over selections, each pair settles every question, so excluded middle holds on every pair and is factually true although neither disjunct need be; in the same spirit, Woodward's fictionalist story is "determinately complete" though "there is no determinate way in which her story is complete" (Woodward 2012, 787). On the story-state view the candidate worlds are alternatives the information leaves open, not ways of settling it, so Scopelessness holds and FEM does not. And opinions spread over

unconstrained selections give the comparison of two tellings in Section 4 even odds, as the PRP does. What I add, then, is a semantics that answers B&H's embedding argument on its own terms while granting their data, a proof that attitudes toward a single fiction cannot decide between their view and it, and a test on which the two come apart.

2 The case for fictional reality

B&H work within the modal approach to truth in fiction. A bare internal claim, such as "Holmes lives on Baker Street" on its natural reading, carries a silent operator $\Box_f$, and is true iff its prejacent holds at every world in a set Fic_f. The *principal truths* of f are the fictional claims that can, at least in principle, be known to be true in f (156): what it states or depicts, what its author intended, and what follows from these against background reality. P-Fic_f is the set of worlds compatible with them. The *standard analysis* sets $\mathrm{Fic}_f = \text{P-Fic}_f$, so that a claim the principal truths leave unsettled is false, and so is its negation.

B&H's central case is the last episode of *JAG*. Bud tosses a fair coin to decide which of Mac and Harm will resign and follow the other, and the series ends with the coin in the air. B&H stipulate, "perhaps counterfactually", that the writers had no intentions about the outcome "and then never thought about the events of JAG again" (161).[1] With the complement "Bud's coin landed heads", they report that *know*, *be sure*, *know whether* and *wish* are unacceptable, while "It's .5 likely that", *wonder whether* and *hope* are acceptable, and *think* and *doubt* are acceptable only for a biased coin (161–167). Frege puzzles aside, the standard analysis validates ATTITUDE EQUIVALENCE: one's attitudes toward a claim's being true in f are one's attitudes toward its being a principal truth (167). Since an informed viewer knows that "Bud's coin landed heads" is not a principal truth, she should know that it is not true in *JAG*, be sure that it is not, and be able to wish that it were. Treating indeterminate claims as undefined does no better: a known gap makes "I wonder whether the King of France is happy" bad, but known fictional indeterminacy does not make "I wonder whether Bud's coin landed heads" bad (169–171). And B&H argue that any view that captures the data with a trivalent conception of undefinedness must let "I know whether p is true, but I don't know whether p" be uttered truly (171).

The embedding argument comes next. B&H find this inference "unimpeachable" (172): "I don't know that Bud's coin landed heads. And I don't know that it failed to land heads. So I don't know whether Bud's coin landed heads." Since "fail to" lexicalises negation, the inference requires SCOPELESSNESS: $\neg\Box_f p$ iff $\Box_f\neg p$ (173). Because $\Box_f$ quantifies over Fic_f, Scopelessness forces Fic_f to be a singleton (175 n. 39), and fictional excluded middle (FEM) follows: $\Box_f p \vee \Box_f\neg p$ (176 n. 40). A second pattern is a fictional analogue of Higginbotham's (1986) quantified conditionals. "Every character in The Breakfast Club failed the test" and "No character in The Breakfast Club passed the test" are equivalent even with the quantifier outside the fiction operator, and "If FEM is invalid, then it's unclear how this is to be explained" (181).

[1] In 2019 *NCIS: Los Angeles* brought Harm and Mac back. According to recaps, Mac had won the toss and Harm had passed up a JAG post in London to join her in San Diego (Hurley 2019; Mitovich 2019), which is tails on B&H's labelling (161). B&H's note 26 cites, as evidence that no one knows how the coin landed, a piece announcing that the sequel "will finally reveal who won the coin flip" (Stein 2019); it is dated a week before the reveal aired. Like B&H, I set this aside.

Finally, the PRP locates the world: $\Box_{f,w}\, p$ iff P-Fic$_{f,w} > p$ is true at w, with $>$ Stalnaker's (1968) conditional (182). The world of f is "the unique world that would accurately represent how things are, were all the principal claims of f really true" (183). Indeterminate counterfactuals, such as "If Flippy had been flipped, it would have landed heads", show the same attitude profile as fiction, which B&H take as "strong abductive support" for the PRP (182): "we see no better way of explaining these similarities" (183). Since similarity rarely favours one candidate world over another, the selection function picks "at random, so to speak" (184), as on the views of arbitrary selection defended by Hawthorne (2005), Schulz (2017) and Bacon (2015) (184 n. 55). So, short of "the word of an oracle", one's evidence "won't be able to rule out any of the possible results" (184).

3 Story states

3.1 The fragment

B&H's step from Scopelessness to a single world (175 n. 39) assumes that the negation in $\neg\Box_f p$ is Boolean negation applied to a universal quantifier over Fic$_f$. If Fic$_f$ had two worlds disagreeing about p, then "not every world in Fic$_f$ is a p-world", and likewise for $\neg p$, and Scopelessness fails. The alternative is to evaluate bare claims against a body of information shifted by the story, so that their negation is the story's own.

1. *Priors.* For each world w, π_w is a probability over worlds encoding w's regularities together with the chances internal to whatever is supposed. It is a Reality Principle of the kind Lewis (1978) and Walton (1990) proposed for truth in fiction (as B&H note, 182 n. 51), applied to credence rather than truth.
2. *Shift.* $P_f(w)$ is the set of worlds compatible with f's principal truths as they stand at w. For an information state s with credence C:
   - $s \oplus f = \bigcup_{w \in s} \operatorname{supp} \pi_w\big(\cdot \mid P_f(w)\big)$;
   - $C \oplus f = \sum_w C(w)\, \pi_w\big(\cdot \mid P_f(w)\big)$.
3. *Bare claims.* A bare declarative φ, with its connectives, embedded counterfactuals and story-internal quantifiers, is interpreted inside the shift, where $|\varphi|$ is its ordinary content.
   - s *supports* $f : \varphi$ iff $s \oplus f \subseteq |\varphi|$;
   - s *rejects* $f : \varphi$ iff $s \oplus f \cap |\varphi| = \varnothing$.
   - A quantifier outside the story binds into it pointwise: $\forall x\, f : \varphi(x)$ is supported iff every instance is supported, and rejected iff some instance is rejected.
4. *Truth.* Internal "true" is transparent: $f : (\varphi \text{ is true}) \equiv f : \varphi$. A bare claim about f is *right* at w, as assessed from a context c, iff $\{w\} \oplus f$ supports it, with f taken as it stands at w at the time of c.
5. *Attitudes.* The story is a parameter of the context, not an operator inside the complement. An attitude verb applies its ordinary entry to the subject's own state shifted by f: $D_S \oplus f$ for her certainties and $C_S \oplus f$ for her credences.

3.2 The embedding patterns

Scopelessness without a world. Because $\oplus$ distributes over unions, support and rejection are settled world by world. So $f : \varphi$ behaves like a homogeneous plural predication. Like "Mr. Ben-

fleet published the books", which is true if he published all of them and whose negation is true if he published none (Križ 2019), it is supported when every candidate world is a φ-world, rejected when none is, and otherwise neither. "Bud's coin didn't land heads" and "Bud's coin failed to land heads" both express $f : \neg h$, supported exactly when $f : h$ is rejected. That is Scopelessness, and the inference B&H call unimpeachable is valid. In their footnote 39, "not every world in Fic_f is a p-world" is a fact about the state, namely that the story does not settle p. It is not the content of any bare claim, so the step from two candidate worlds to a failure of Scopelessness never starts. Scopelessness needs a single point of evaluation, not a single world.

Excluded middle. $f : (h \vee \neg h)$ is supported, and with transparent truth so is "Either 'the coin landed heads' is true or 'the coin landed tails' is true". But neither $f : h$ nor $f : \neg h$ is supported, so FEM, read as a claim about what the story makes so, fails.

The Higginbotham pattern. On B&H's mixed reading, "No character in The Breakfast Club passed the test" says of every character x that it is not the case that, in the film, x passed, and "Every character in The Breakfast Club failed the test" says of every character x that, in the film, x did not pass (their (43)). Negation of a homogeneous claim swaps support and rejection, so for each x the two open sentences are supported together and rejected together, and by the clause for quantifying in, so are the quantified claims. Von Fintel's (1997, 33) proposal that bare conditionals carry a homogeneity presupposition, so that they "obey the Excluded Middle", would explain Higginbotham's conditional equivalence in the same way. FEM is not needed.

Trivalence. The view has gaps, so B&H's challenge to trivalent views (171) applies. With a transparent internal truth predicate, "I know whether p is true, but I don't know whether p" is, on its bare reading, a contradiction, and so it is bad, as B&H say; so is "I wonder whether p, but I don't wonder whether p is true". The first is acceptable only when "true" is heard as "true according to the story", and then it should be: "I know whether it's true in *JAG* that the coin landed heads (it isn't), but I don't know whether the coin landed heads."

Not vagueness. B&H distinguish fictional from vague indeterminacy because vague claims are bad under attitudes and invite "Yes and no" (185–187). The candidate worlds of a story state are not precisifications of "heads". They are factual alternatives, weighted by chances, which the story leaves open. So *wonder* and *hope* are licensed and "Yes and no" is not; the answer is "the story doesn't say". The indeterminacy is neither semantic, nor metaphysical, nor ignorance of a hidden fact. It is the incompleteness of the information a work provides, which is Lewis's view, made fit for attitudes.

3.3 The attitudes

For a viewer who knows *JAG*, $D \oplus f$ contains heads-worlds and tails-worlds, and $C \oplus f$ gives each .5 (2/3 and 1/3 for the biased coin). *Know*, *be sure* and *know whether*, which require support in $D \oplus f$, are unacceptable. "It's .5 likely" is acceptable. *Think*, which B&H gloss as finding something "more likely than not" (175), is unacceptable for the fair coin and acceptable for the biased one, and *doubt* likewise. *Wonder* and *hope*, which require the question to be open in $D \oplus f$, are

acceptable. *Wish*, which requires $\neg h$ to be supported, is unacceptable. No verb needs a special projection rule. Each keeps its lexical entry, and all look at the same shifted state.[2]

3.4 Absorption

On B&H's view, a credence that p is true in f is a credence about where the selection lands. They need such credences to track in-story chances; they suggest that a rational agent "will be doxastically indifferent to the various possibilities compatible with the principal truths" (175), while granting that they lack "a direct argument" that credence has the needed structure. Two bridge principles make the suggestion precise. Both are my strengthenings of it.

- **Chance–selection link.** Given any world w, S's credence that $s\big(P_f(w), w\big)$ lies in X is $\pi_w\big(X \mid P_f(w)\big)$.
- **Openness.** The selections that S's certainties leave open, given w, are exactly the support of $\pi_w\big(\cdot \mid P_f(w)\big)$. This is B&H's claim that evidence cannot "rule out any of the possible results" (184), together with the assumption that π_w gives positive weight to each possible result.

Given both, for every attitude in B&H's table and any single fiction, S bears the attitude to $\Box_f\varphi$ on B&H's view iff she bears it to $f : \varphi$ on the story-state view.[3] So the attitude data cannot decide between the views, and neither can the counterfactual parallel B&H draw, since any view on which these attitudes are evaluated against a shifted state predicts it. Together with the embedding patterns, this answers the first stage of B&H's case: nothing in it requires a single world.

Absorption has a limit. It fixes credences one story at a time, and says nothing about how the selections for two stories are related. Attitudes that compare two tellings of a story are where the views can part.

4 The strengthening test

4.1 Counterfactuals

Any adequate theory of counterfactuals must respect two judgements about chancy outcomes. Suppose a fair coin was tossed and landed heads.

1. *Relevant strengthening can change the outcome.* "Had the coin been tossed in a gust of wind, it would still have landed heads" is not true. Where a coin lands depends sensitively on the conditions of the toss.
2. *Irrelevant strengthening cannot.* "Had a moth been fluttering in the next room, the coin would still have landed heads" is fine. Cases like Morgenbesser's coin suggest that "only match among

[2] Blumberg and Strohminger (2025, sec. 4.1) observe that "Bill believes that Juliet died, but he hopes that she survived" is infelicitous, which fits a view on which hope toward a story is constrained by the same state as belief about it.

[3] For credence, average the selection over the link: $C_S\big(\Box_f\varphi\big) = \sum_w C_S(w)\,\pi_w\big(|\varphi| \mid P_f(w)\big) = (C_S \oplus f)(|\varphi|)$. This is a version of Lewis's result that "the probability of a Stalnaker conditional with a possible antecedent is the probability of the consequent after imaging on the antecedent" (1976, 311). For certainty, Openness gives: S is sure of $\Box_f\varphi$ iff every open selection is a φ-world iff $D_S \oplus f \subseteq |\varphi|$. The other attitudes in the table are defined from these.

those facts causally independent of the antecedent should count towards similarity" (Schaffer 2004, 305).

A Stalnakerian can respect both. Order worlds by similarity to actuality, and break the many near-ties by agreement with one fixed assignment of values to the exogenous variables of the apt causal model, the same assignment for every antecedent. A gust is a cause of the landing, so strengthening by a gust redraws the coin; the moth is not, so it leaves the coin alone. Since the PRP evaluates fiction with the very function that evaluates counterfactuals, this is the best it can do. If a selection function of this kind fails the test below, the PRP fails it.

4.2 The case

Suppose that, years after *JAG* ended, its makers produced a reunion special set in the minutes before the finale's last scene. In it we see that a sudden gust caught the coin as Bud tossed it. We still never see how it lands, and, as in B&H's stipulation, the makers have no view about it. The special is consistent with everything in *JAG*, so its principal content, B, is a subset of *JAG*'s, A. About the series as it now stands, consider:

(A) It's about even odds that, if there had been no gust, the coin would have landed the other way.

(B) It's about even odds that, if the writers had left the special out, the coin would have landed differently.

(C) If the special had shown the coin landing heads, it would have landed heads.

(D) It's about even odds that, if the writers had left the special out, the coin would have landed heads.

Table 1: Is the sentence acceptable?

	(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)
My judgement	yes	no	yes	yes
Predicted by the PRP	yes	yes	yes	yes
Predicted by the story state	yes	no	yes	yes

These are my judgements, offered on the same footing as B&H's own.[4] (B) and (D) share an antecedent and a frame, a credence report on a counterfactual about the telling with a bare fictional consequent, and differ only in their consequents. (D) shows that speakers give that consequent the reading B&H's credence data require, on which it can be .5 likely; a reading on which it concerns what the story settles would make (D) absurd. (C) shows that the consequent follows the counterfactual telling. So the rejection of (B) is not a retreat to a "what the story says" reading. (A) and (B) then differ only in whether the antecedent removes the gust from the story's events or the special from its telling.

[4]They could be tested. Cross the locus of the antecedent (the gust or the telling) with the relevance of the omitted detail (a gust, or a scene from Bud's childhood), and elicit probabilities. The PRP with causal tie-breaking predicts about .5 for the relevant telling condition and about 0 for the irrelevant one; the story-state view predicts about 0 for both. Viewers may assume that the makers decided how the coin landed, so ask, and analyse by the answer.

4.3 What the PRP predicts

Under the PRP, the world of the series as it now stands is $s(B, @)$, the closest world to actuality at which everything in *JAG* and the special holds. Had the special been left out, the world of the series would have been $s(A, w')$, where w' is the closest world at which the writers did not make the special. I assume $s(A, w') = s(A, @)$: the special's absence does not alter which worlds are most like actuality in respects bearing on Bud's coin. Dropping the assumption only adds a further source of difference.

Is $s(A, @)$ a world in which a gust catches the coin? Similarity to actuality is silent, since there is no actual toss to match. But by the chance–selection link, an agent's credence that the selection lands on a gust-world is the in-story chance of a gust at that moment, which is small. So almost certainly $s(A, @) \notin B$ and $s(B, @) \neq s(A, @)$. The two worlds differ in a cause of the coin's landing, and that is exactly the difference that, by judgement 1, redraws the coin. Whatever tie-breaking gets (A) right, by letting the landing depend on the gust, makes $s(A, @)$ and $s(B, @)$ disagree about the landing about half the time. So the PRP predicts that (B) is acceptable, just as (D) is. Could it keep (B) false by evaluating the bare consequent at the actual series' world, whatever the counterfactual says about the telling? Then (C) fails: had the special shown heads, the coin would have landed heads only if it does at $s(B, @)$, which is even odds.

The PRP makes adding a detail to a story the same operation as strengthening the antecedent of a counterfactual. For a detail that bears on an open chancy question, strengthening an antecedent can change the answer, and adding the detail to a story does not. No selection function that gets the counterfactuals right gets the fiction right.

4.4 What the story state predicts

On the story-state view, a story is a body of information, and adding a detail removes possibilities without moving any. So:

- **(A)** For each candidate world of the series as it stands, the counterfactual "if there had been no gust, the coin would have landed the other way" is evaluated at that world. The view needs no particular semantics for counterfactuals, only that credence in a counterfactual about a chancy outcome goes by the chance of the consequent given the antecedent, as on Moss's (2013) "Bridge" principle, which she pairs with a variably strict semantics, or on Stalnaker's semantics with a chance–selection link. Either way, (A) gets about .5.
- **(C)** In the counterfactual telling, the coin lands heads at every candidate world.
- **(D)** In *JAG* without the special, the coin lands heads at about half the candidate worlds.
- **(B)** "Differently" compares the coin in two tellings. The comparison needs a way of pairing the candidates of one telling with those of the other. The natural pairing for bodies of information is the one that makes them differ no more than their own probabilities require, the counterpart for comparisons of Lewis's observation that imaging "involves no gratuitous movement of probability" (1976, 311). Formally, it is the coupling of the two candidate measures that maximises agreement on the question at issue. With and without the special, the coin has the same chance of heads, so the coupling makes them agree everywhere, and "would have landed differently" gets probability 0. The coupling governs only comparisons between tellings, one question at a

time; it plays no role in bare claims about a single telling or in counterfactuals inside one. It has a cost, which I accept. It also predicts that, had the special shown a breeze rather than a gust, the coin would not have landed differently, so for comparisons between tellings it holds open outcomes fixed while the told causes vary, as the defaults view of Section 5 does for worlds. The difference is that it posits no world.[5]

The PRP has no such freedom. It assigns each telling one world, and the world of the shorter telling is not the world of the longer one.

4.5 Revelation and time

Some hearers will take the special to reveal what had already happened in a fixed fictional past, so that leaving it out would leave the events untouched. This is a version of what McGonigal (2013, 167–68) calls "extreme realism" about serial fiction, on which there is already a determinate matter of fact before later episodes are made; he grants that cliffhanger serials invite that attitude before rejecting the view. That reading also makes (B) unacceptable. But it is not the PRP. It is a rule on which, when two tellings are compared, the shorter telling's world is chosen inside the longer one, and Section 5 shows that no rule of that kind can govern counterfactuals in general. The revelation reading and the story-state view come apart elsewhere. Consider "If the writers had left the special out, there would still have been a gust." On the revelation reading it is true. On the story-state view it is not, since without the special the gust has only its small in-story chance, and the coupling cannot make it agree with a certainty. Whichever way hearers go on that sentence, they reject (B), and the PRP as stated does not.

The contrast can also be posed over time, and there it bites directly on both of B&H's options for fictional change. If a fiction is a function from times to worlds, so that "there are as many such worlds as there are times in which the principal fictional truths change" (194), then the special changed the world of *JAG*, and by the reasoning above it is even odds that it changed how the coin landed. On their other option the special made a new version, and since versions' truths "(whether principal or otherwise) can come quite dramatically apart" (194), it is even odds that the two versions disagree about the coin. Both verdicts are wrong. B&H's defaults, on which we speak of the final or most recent version (193–194), keep them out of most talk, as would relativism about assessment (McGonigal 2013); their discussion, like the literature on serial fiction (McGonigal 2013; Caplan 2014; Lee 2024), concerns change that revises. But comparing the times or versions brings the verdicts back, and counterfactuals about the telling make the comparison without asking hearers to hold two versions in view. The story-state view's assessment clause mirrors MacFarlane's (2003) treatment of future contingents, and B&H's single world per stage is the fictional analogue of the "thin red line", positing which, he holds, "amounts to giving up objective indeterminism" (2003, 325).

[5]For a detail that shifts the in-story chances, say one that makes heads nine times as likely as tails, the coupling predicts a probability of .4 that the coin would have landed differently, the least the change in chances permits, and it leaves (D) at .5.

5 What remains of the single world

The strengthening test refutes the PRP as B&H state it: fictional truth as counterfactual truth at the actual world, under the selection function counterfactuals use. It does not refute every single-world view. There are three ways to keep a single world, and each passes the test.

Anchoring. Let the selection function vary with context, so that whenever two tellings are under discussion, the world of the shorter one is chosen inside the longer. Then the shorter telling inherits the longer one's world, and (B) is unacceptable. This is the revelation reading made into semantics. But it cannot be a general rule for counterfactuals. Applied to the toss itself, it would require that whenever "if the coin had been tossed" and "if it had been tossed in a gust" are discussed together, the first select a gust-world. Then merely raising the possibility of a gust would make "Had the coin been tossed, there would have been a gust" true, which it is not. So anchoring is a rule for fiction alone.

Defaults. Fix one assignment of values to the exogenous variables of every story, or rank the questions a world answers and fix a default answer to each, and let the world of f be the P-Fic $_f$-world that best matches the defaults. Rank the landing above the gust, and the special leaves the landing alone. But actuality supplies no values for the variables of merely possible coins, so the defaults are not similarity to actuality; they are a stipulated default world for possibilia. An ordering that keeps outcomes fixed while their causes vary is not the counterfactual one.

Path-dependence. Select the new world from the old: the world of the extended series is the closest B-world to $s(A, @)$, on a backtracking ordering that holds the old world's effects fixed. That passes the test. But the world is no longer fixed from actuality, so this is not the PRP either. It also makes the open details of a finished work depend on the order in which its parts were released, and lets an earlier arbitrary selection, which no judgement tracks, set the coin.

Supervaluating over admissible selection functions, an option B&H mention, following Stalnaker (1980), and reject for themselves (185), and the shape of Woodward's (2012) and Khoo's (2026, sec. 4) proposals, abandons the single world. It passes the test only if every admissible selection keeps the landing fixed while the gust varies, which is the defaults view imposed as a penumbral constraint.

Each survivor is a rule for fiction that counterfactuals reject. That is the precise sense in which fiction is not counterfactual. B&H's reason to identify the two was the parallel in our attitudes, and Section 3 shows that the parallel is predicted without the identification.

How do the survivors compare with the story state? Both need the priors π_w; on the single-world side they enter through the chance–selection link. The single world adds a default world, an anchoring rule or a selection path, none of which anyone could know or any judgement tracks, and in return gets classical logic for the fiction operator and bivalence for every bare claim. The story state adds gaps governed by the logic of homogeneity, a coupling for comparing tellings, and two truth notions, transparent internal truth and assessment-sensitive rightness. By absorption and the test, the two predict the same attitudes, embedding patterns and strengthening judgements, so the data no longer favour the single world.

B&H put the choice this way. Their argument is "fundamentally conditional in nature: if we are not systematically mistaken in our judgments about the kinds of attitudes that are appropriate to take toward indeterminate fictional claims, then there must be facts of the matter about any meaningful question one can ask about what's true in a work of fiction—facts whose grounds will in many cases be almost entirely arbitrary" (188). I grant the antecedent: unlike Oppy and Raivars, I accept B&H's judgements. The story state shows that the conditional is false, because the judgements are explained without the facts. Nor do the facts earn their keep as a unification with counterfactuals. What remains is bivalence for its own sake, bought with arbitrary and unknowable facts. B&H's argument for the single world was abductive (175, 182–183), and by that standard the single world is now unsupported.

6 Objections

Isn't this just the standard analysis? No. The standard analysis also lets a story's truths grow monotonically, and it gets (B) and (C) right. But it gets (A) and (D) wrong. Without the special, the story settles nothing about the coin, so on the standard analysis "the coin would have landed heads" is false wherever the counterfactual takes us, and the credence in (D) is 0. Likewise the story does not settle what would have happened without the gust, so the credence in (A) is 0. The .5s come from the priors. The standard analysis is right about truth and wrong about credence; the story state keeps its view of truth and adds a Reality Principle for credence.

Viewers will think the makers decided. A special that withholds an outcome invites the thought that someone knows it, and a rejection of (B) on that ground supports neither view. The stipulation that the makers have no view addresses this, as B&H's does for their own case. The recaps of the real sequel, which treated it as revealing an answer the makers held, show how strong the pull is; but that is a datum about how viewers construe makers, not about what an undecided story makes true.

Does the test tell against Lewis too? No. Lewis's analyses also use counterfactuals, but variably strict ones. On his Analysis 1, "In the fiction f, φ" is non-vacuously true iff some world where f is told as known fact and φ is true "differs less from our actual world, on balance, than does any world where f is told as known fact and φ is not true" (Lewis 1978, 42). No single world is selected, and a detail that some of the closest such worlds already satisfy leaves the story's truths in place. The test tells against the Stalnakerian identification, not Lewis's, though Lewis's analyses, like the standard analysis, still need the priors to get the credences right.

7 Conclusion

B&H showed that the standard analysis, with the attitude equivalence it validates, mispredicts our attitudes toward fictional indeterminacy, and they were right about that. They then argued that the attitudes and the logic of fictional talk require a single world, and that counterfactuals locate it. The first argument fails because the attitudes and the embedding patterns are explained by a story state weighted by a Reality Principle for credence, which needs only one point of evaluation, not one world. The second fails because stories and counterfactuals respond differently to added detail. A detail that bears on an open chancy question can change the answer to a counterfactual.

In a story it cannot, because the story never gave an answer to change. What is left is a single world located by nothing our judgements track. That does not prove that nothing makes it true that Holmes had an odd number of hairs. It does mean that B&H have given us no reason to think anything does, and that Lewis's verdict, that the worlds of Sherlock Holmes are plural, is the better-supported view.

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